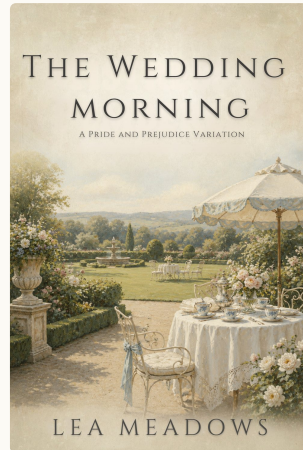


A BY SMALLER PROOFS BONUS SCENE

The Wedding Morning

*The wedding the book stops just short of — in
Elizabeth's voice.*



By eight o'clock on her wedding morning, Elizabeth Bennet had been kissed by her mother four times, wept over twice, prophesied at length, and informed — on the authority of a woman who had been married more than three-and-twenty years and had never once been to Derbyshire — exactly what Derbyshire would require of her. She had also been dressed, undressed half an inch at the shoulder, and dressed again, for Mrs. Bennet had discovered at the last possible moment that the gown which had been entirely perfect at every previous viewing was now, on the only morning it could not be altered, a quarter of an inch too high at the throat.

"You will be looked at, Lizzy," her mother said, as though this were news, and a misfortune. "Ten thousand a year. There will be people who come only to look."

"Then I am glad I shall be too occupied to look back," Elizabeth said, and held still while Jane, with the patience of a sister who had survived the same examination an hour earlier, set the last pin.

In the glass the two of them stood together for a moment — Jane all serene fairness, herself a darker, quicker thing beside her — and Elizabeth thought, not for the first time that week, that the strangeness of the day was not that she was to be married. The strangeness was that she was to be married *and happy*,

and that the two facts, which she had once been quite certain could not be made to share a room, were standing now in the same gown, waiting to be looked at.

"There," Jane said softly. "Now you are exactly yourself."

"Am I to be married as myself? Mama has been at considerable pains to improve me."

"Mama," said Jane, "has been at considerable pains to improve the throat of your gown. You she gave up improving years ago, which is why she loves you."

Below them the house performed its overture. A door; another door; Kitty's voice asking where the white ribbon had gone and Mary's voice answering, with the air of one quoting Scripture, that vanity in the matter of ribbons was the surest sign of a frivolous mind, and then Kitty's voice again, lower, asking Mary to help her find the frivolous ribbon anyway.

Somewhere Mrs. Bennet revived herself. She had been reviving herself at intervals all week, and with such regularity that Mr. Bennet had observed she was becoming almost dependable, and that he should be sorry to lose the habit when the wedding was over and there was nothing left to revive from.

Elizabeth went down.

Her father was in the hall, in his good coat, holding his hat in both hands as though it were a thing he did not quite trust himself with. He saw her coming down the stairs and did not say, at once, anything dry.

That, more than the gown or the ribbons or the four maternal kisses, told Elizabeth what the morning was.

"Well," he managed, after a moment. "You will do."

"High praise, Papa, on such a day."

He turned his hat once in his hands. "I will say this. I have given a great deal of thought to which of my daughters I could least afford to lose, and I have concluded that you have arranged matters very ill, in being the one I shall miss, and in marrying the one man in England I cannot fault you for preferring."

He offered his arm, and she took it, and they went out to the carriage together while behind them Mrs. Bennet discovered that she had not, after all, finished crying.



The church was cold in the way of old country churches, stone holding the night long after the morning had warmed the lanes. Beeswax warmed in the service candles near the rail, where someone had set a small posy of late roses with more love than skill; underfoot, the old stone kept its damp.

She would remember that she had braced herself to be looked at, and had forgotten to be, because the only person who held her attention was at the front, turned, watching her come.

In the hall at Pemberley, with Mrs. Reynolds a step behind, he was Mr. Darcy. Here, before God and the better part of two counties, he was Mr. Darcy still; she would not have his name aloud until they were alone. And yet what she saw in his face was William — the private stillness he wore when feeling had gone past the place where his composure could manage it, and he had stopped trying to manage it, and had decided instead simply to stand there, letting her see it and letting the rest of the world arrange itself as it could.

He had not, in the end, found a dramatic way to prove himself. He had told her once that he wished he had. That he would have liked there to be some single great act she could point to—some rescue, some sacrifice, some thunderclap of merit that would have settled the question of his worth past all argument. And she had told him that she did not want the thunderclap. She had had enough, in her life, of men who were splendid once and ordinary ever after. What she wanted was the smaller, harder proof, offered again and not regretted: the same man, on an ordinary morning, choosing the right thing without applause.

She came forward on her father's arm, into the body of the church, toward the man who had given her a great many ordinary mornings, and meant to give her the rest of them, and she found that her hands, which she had expected to shake, were perfectly steady.

The vows were plain, prescribed, and stronger for being so. Jane, as eldest, was called first; she married Mr. Bingley with a radiance that did more for the cold church than all its candles, and Mr. Bingley, who had wept at the rehearsal and had sworn he would not weep at the wedding, wept at the wedding.

Then the service turned to Elizabeth. Mr. Darcy looked very much as Mr. Darcy ought to look: grave, exact, irreproachable. Only his eyes failed him; they res-

ted on her with such open feeling that she let her own answer him, and did not look away.

When it was done — when she was, in the plain unanswerable language of the register, *Elizabeth Darcy*, the ink not yet dry — her husband offered his arm to lead her out, and she laid her gloved hand upon his sleeve.

"You are cold," he said quietly, which was not what he meant.

"I am married," she answered, which was.

The corner of his mouth moved. "Yes," he said. "No remedy for it now."

At the church door Darcy was claimed by Mr. Bingley and the press of well-wishers, and Elizabeth had only enough time to discover that steadiness was not a permanent condition before Kitty came to her side.

Kitty had been crying since the second hymn, but quietly, with a restraint Elizabeth would once have thought beyond her. She stood now with Georgiana Darcy at her side — the two of them had stood up together throughout, a matched pair of younger sisters trading the same nervous half-smile — and she put her handkerchief into Elizabeth's hand with brisk competence. Elizabeth pressed it once beneath her eye.

"Don't tell Mama you cried," Kitty said. "She'll say it was for joy and make a speech."

"It *was* for joy."

"All the more reason," said Kitty, with a wisdom that had cost her a great deal to acquire, "not to tell Mama." And Georgiana, beside her, laughed — actually laughed, out loud, in a churchyard. It was a thing she could not have done in May and could do now in October, because a summer had happened to her, and to all of them. None of it would have happened at all if a frightened girl had not, one morning at a breakfast table, found out what her voice was for.

Elizabeth saw the two girls together and felt a quiet astonishment. She had come into Derbyshire believing she had ruined everything by misreading one man. She was leaving it with two younger sisters who had found, in each other, a friend.

"Come to Pemberley soon," Georgiana said to Kitty, suddenly shy again, the way she went shy when something mattered. "The house is — it is better when there are people in it who laugh."

"Then it shall be very much improved," Elizabeth said, "for I mean to fill it with as much laughter as I can."

A few minutes later, Mr. Darcy found her again, and they were handed into the carriage for Longbourn amid all the noise and good wishes a wedding could produce.



The wedding breakfast was at Longbourn, and Longbourn rose to it.

Mrs. Bennet had ordered, planned, countermanded, and re-ordered the breakfast so many times that the cook had taken to writing down only every third instruction, on the sound principle that two of any three would shortly be reversed; and the result, against all probability, was splendid. There were ham and tongue, eggs and hot rolls, toast enough for a militia regiment, chocolate at one end of the table, the wedding cake in the middle, and the good wine Mr. Bennet kept for occasions he privately considered did not exist.

Beside Elizabeth's plate lay a small thing, carved in pale wood, set where she could not miss it — not one of the little animals from the Lambton fair, but kin to them.

She picked it up and had to set down her glass.

"Where did this come from?"

Her husband, seated beside her, did not look at the little carving.

"From the same boy," said Mr. Darcy. "I found, after July, that two had not been enough."

"You sent for another?"

"I did."

"On a day you believed I would never have you."

"Yes."

"And you have now smuggled it onto my wedding plate like a schoolboy passing a note across a form."

"Sentimental, I fear." He cast a quick glance at her.

She considered. "Sentimental is not the word I should choose."

"What word should you choose?"

"I am still deciding," she said. "It will take me some years. You must be patient."

He let the smile come, briefly, the way he did only when there was no one near enough to be astonished by it. She matched it, and closed her hand around the little carved animal, and kept it.

Across the room Mary, who had been waiting for a lull with the patience of a woman who has prepared remarks, achieved her lull and rose to fill it.

"Marriage," Mary announced, "is a solemn institution, not to be entered into —"

"Mary," said Mr. Bennet, without raising his eyes from his plate, "is going to favor us with her views on the solemnity of the institution, and I have promised her she may, in full, this evening, when the carriages are gone and I am asleep. Before breakfast, however, we will take the solemnity as read, and have the cake."

Mary sat, only slightly wounded, and was consoled — to everyone's surprise, most of all her own — by Kitty, who slipped into the chair beside her and said something low that made the corner of Mary's serious mouth turn up.

Miss Bingley and the Hursts were there, of course, very properly dressed and very properly pleased. Mrs. Hurst attached herself to Jane with sisterly consequence, and Miss Bingley offered Elizabeth every felicitation due to Mrs. Darcy, though none that might be mistaken for pleasure.

Lady Catherine de Bourgh had been invited, in terms of perfect correctness, and had declined, in terms of formidable correctness. No place had been left for her; Mrs. Bennet would never have permitted a chair to stand idle at a wedding breakfast. And yet Elizabeth was aware of the absence all the same.

She felt the absence chiefly through Darcy. He gave no outward sign — he ate, he spoke to her uncle Gardiner about trout, he received Mrs. Bennet's raptures with a patience that three months ago he could not have counterfeited and now,

somehow, partly meant. But once, when Miss Bingley observed that Lady Catherine must be much regretted, Elizabeth saw his hand pause beside his glass before he answered, perfectly, that his aunt had sent her regrets.

She said nothing. There would be time for Lady Catherine's refusal, and it was not the wedding breakfast. But Elizabeth marked the small pause beside Darcy's glass, and knew that the refusal was less an end than a postponement.

It was later, when the noise had moved on to other things, that Darcy told her the rest of it. Anne had written — to him, in her own hand, separately from her mother — a few lines wishing them both well.

"My cousin has never once written to me of her own accord," he said, low, as though turning over something he could not quite account for. "She wished us happy. I believe she meant it."

Elizabeth kept that, too. But for now there was cake.



The leave-taking was long, because everything at Longbourn was long, and because Mrs. Bennet, having begun to say goodbye before the breakfast had properly ended, was determined to extract from the farewell every drop of feeling it could be made to yield.

"Derbyshire," she kept saying, as though the county were a sentence. "So very far. You will write. You will write directly you arrive, and again the next day, and you will tell me *everything* — the house, the plate, the carriages, whether Mrs. Darcy's apartments face the morning sun — oh, *Mrs. Darcy* — Lizzy, you are *Mrs. Darcy* — "

"I am, Mama," Elizabeth said gently, "and I shall write, and the house faces every direction at once, being very large, so you may be easy on the point of sun."

By then the farewell had carried them as far as the front steps, where Darcy's carriage stood waiting. Her father came to adjust her cloak, though it required no adjustment.

"Lizzy," he said, settling the edge at her shoulder with great attention, "I find I am very pleased, my dear, and I am going to go and be pleased somewhere your mother cannot see me do it."

He pressed her hand and went; and Elizabeth, who had been steady through the vows and the whole cold beautiful service, found her eyes stinging at Longbourn over the single word *pleased*.

It was her uncle Gardiner who rescued her before Mrs. Bennet could notice. He drew her aside under the pretense of inspecting the carriage horses — which were Darcy's, and beautiful, and required no inspection — and said, low, his attention on the grooms rather than her:

"He gave you a fair summer, Lizzy. I watched him do it. A man may be civil to a woman's tradesman uncle for an afternoon; any man may manage that. To be civil all summer, in his own country, to the uncle in Cheapside, with no one of consequence watching to applaud him for it — " Mr. Gardiner shook his head. "That is not manners. That is character. I told your aunt so in July, and she told me I had said it three times already, which I daresay I had."

"You approve of him, then," Elizabeth said. She knew the answer, but on this morning of all mornings, she wanted to hear it from this uncle.

"I love him," said Mr. Gardiner simply, "for making you look as you do. There is no higher reason, and I shall need no other." Then, because Mr. Gardiner could not leave tenderness quite undefended, he added, with a perfectly straight face, "Also his trout are remarkable, and I intend to fish them shamelessly for the rest of my life." Elizabeth laughed — really laughed, the first full laugh of the whole solemn shining day — and was still laughing when her husband came to hand her into the carriage.

He heard the laugh and glanced from her uncle to her, and something in his face softened. Elizabeth thought he was beginning to understand that he had married not only her, but a family that, among its undeniable absurdities, contained men like Edward Gardiner.

"Sir," Darcy said to her uncle, "the river is yours whenever you will come."

"You will regret that, nephew."

"I have begun," said Darcy, "to suspect that the things I am told I shall regret are, on the whole, the ones I am gladdest of."

When he handed her into the carriage for Derbyshire, she felt it: no leather, no kid, no proper barrier at all. His hand was bare around hers for the single necessary moment before she stepped up, his thumb warm against her knuckles

— a small and entirely deliberate impropriety that no one but Elizabeth would ever notice.

Then he got in after her, and the door was shut on Longbourn, on the noise and the love and the laughter, and on the whole of the life that had made her.

The road north waited, and Pemberley at the end of it. Elizabeth sat beside her husband and found, to her own astonishment, that she was ready for both.

*Elizabeth and Darcy's story begins in By Smaller Proofs, and
continues in A Proper Bloom.*

— Lea Meadows